

Kevin Li Initial 1 on 1

Situation 1: Starting With a New Team

When a manager joins a team, the first round of 1:1 meetings should be treated as discovery conversations. The goal is to understand how the team actually operates, what is working well and where problems exist.

These conversations help reveal the difference between the official process and the real one.

Understanding the Team

- What part of the team's work do you think is going especially well right now?
 - Struggling to find something that is going well with the work being done
 - The people
 - Tim is trying to institute processes which will be helpful
 - Connor is trying his best to push back on stakeholders
 - Enjoyed working with Vince and Magaly
 - Learns a lot from working with Vince
 - Interactions with people
- If you could change one thing about how the team operates, what would it be?
- What part of our workflow feels harder than it should be?

Execution and Process

- Where do workstreams usually slow down?
- What tends to surprise us during projects?
- What types of work cause the most interruptions?

Leadership Expectations

- What do you think this team needs most from a manager?
- What did your previous manager do that worked well?
- What did you wish they had done differently?

Hidden Problems

- What issue do people complain about privately but not in meetings?
 - Nothing he can really think about.
- What causes the most frustration on the team today?

These questions help the manager understand the real operating environment of the team.

Notes

- Staten Island NY
 - Lived there his whole life
- Video games
 - State as fire 2
 - Binding of Issac
- Main issue right now
 - A lot of high priority tasks
 - Only seeing a small portion because Connor and Tim have been filtering them out
 - Need more capacity
 - Adding some folks temporarily
 - Kit
 - Charlie
 - Jeremy
 - When they leave, they will be passing off the work
 - Might end up in a worse spot when they leave
- A lot of interruptions
 - Had like 6 tickets open at one time
 - This is a regular occurrence
- Connor has some feature asks that the team wants to work on it
 - Something always comes up
- Team itself
 - Very difficult to understand how everything works
 - Huge bottleneck with Vince
 - Coupled with the other issues, Vince doesn't have a ton of time to really help
 - Trying to utilize Claude to help
 - Huge knowledge gap
 - Probably a lot of difficult things only Vince can solve
- Working on this team feels a lot like keeping the lights on
 - Connor has a lot of big project, but doesn't feel we get to work on them
- What does he want to do
 - Work on actual work
- New Hire
 - Async processes / Queue based working

- SQS/SNS
- WIZZ security tool
- Teraform
- Kubernetes
- Infrastructure would be his weakness
- Don't really need front end work
- Probably can't hire for
 - Siloed team
 - Need someone who like to collaborate with people and make sure people work together
- Career goals
 - Likes Implementing feature work
 - Product work is what he prefers doing
 - Next level
 - Working towards the next level
 - P3 right now, looking to get to P4
 - What are the goals/milestones he should work towards for the rest of the year.
 - Review feedback
 - Building relationships across teams would be helpful
 - He was under the impression that things were going well but he would like to know my opinion on it.

Continue

- Defining and coordinating technical processes for the team. Your efforts to manage the split release process and then merge it back in enabled the team to hit our MVP roadmap commitments at re:Invent.
- Mentoring your teammates and deeply investigating the team's most challenging bugs. You have improved many of the junior team member's ability to triage on-call tasks. Additionally, your investigation into overlap reports built trust between the team and our stakeholders, like technical solutions.

Consider

- Continuing to voice your opinions to me and even to the broader team. You are thoughtful and more often than not correct. I benefit from when you challenge my assumptions and opinions.
- Establishing stronger relationships with senior engineers on other teams within LS. Nimbus has been fairly siloed for your time here which has been out of your control. As we fold the product back into Linkage, we'll collaborate more with other teams within LS.

